Sickened

By Julie Gregory

JULIE: **(Pg 3)** For starters, I was a sick kid. Bean-pole skinny, I bruised easy and wilted in a snap. Kids in school used to walk straight up to me and ask point-blank if I was anorexic. But I wasn't; just sick. And Mom bent over backwards trying to find out what was wrong with me. It wasn't just that I had a heart problem. It was everything rolled into one, bleeding together with so many indistinguishable layers that to get to the root of it was impossible, like peeling off every layer of an onion, and when I got old enough to peel the onion myself, every layer made me cry.

MOM: **(Pg 4)** Look, dammit, this kid is sick, all right? Just look at her. And so help me God, if she dies on me because you can't find anything wrong with her, I'll sue you for every sent you got.

JULIE: Her voice trailed after any doctor who said no more tests could be done, stalked him down the corridor, sliced through the silence of the hallway. *(to Mom)*

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Don't worry, Mom. It's okay. We'll go find another one.

MOM: Look, I'm sacrificing my life to find out what the hell is wrong with you. So stop *screwing* it up when we get in here by acting all normal. Show them how sick you are, okay?

INTRODUCTION

A young girl is perched on the cold chrome of yet another doctor's examining table, missing yet another day of school. It's four o'clock and she hasn't been allowed to eat anything all day. Her mother, on the other hand, seems curiously excited. She checks her teeth once more for lipstick, and as the doctor enters, shoots the little girl a warning glance. This child will not ruin her plans . . . Munchausen by Proxy is a type of child abuse in which a parent exaggerates, fabricates, or induces symptoms of a medical condition in a child that leads to unnecessary and potentially harmful medical care. Julie Gregory was a victim . . . and this is her story:

Sickened by Julie Gregory.

JULIE: **(Pg 23)** Today, I'm back at [the doctor] getting seen for my headaches. Mom and I sit in the examining room, waiting.

MOM: How do you act when you're sick, Julie? Show me.

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JULIE: *(slouches, limbs dangling, tongue out and bottom lip away from her teeth, a glazed expression on her face)*

MOM: That's right. Now what do you think the doctor is going to say if he comes in here and you're sitting up and all smiling? Do you think he's going to believe me that you're sick? You got to show him how sick you are. *(Doctor enters)*

DOCTOR: So you say Julie's been running a fever along with some sore throats? *(taking notes in Julie's chart)*

MOM: **(Pg 26-27)** Well, I've caught it up at a hundred and one, but it seems to be low grade all the time and she has these, oh, I don't know what you'd call them, headaches, I guess, don't you Julie?

JULIE: I look between both of them. What is a headache exactly? Is it when my eyes hurt? Is it when I'm dizzy on the bus? I'm trying to guess, hoping it's the right answer. *(to Mom and Doctor)* I'm not really sure.

MOM: Jesus, Julie, we've been seeing you sick and you've been telling me you've had headaches in the car all this week. Remember when you've been carsick? *(to Doctor)* There's got to be something wrong with a kid that doesn't even remember how sick she was just

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yesterday. *(to Julie)* Julie, stop wasting the man's time and tell him what's going on with you. *(threateningly)* I mean it!

JULIE: **(Pg 28-29)** Another week has gone by and nothing has changed. Mom and I sit in [the doctor's] office waiting for Dr. Phillips.

MOM: Now, we're going to tell Dr. Phillips about the dull pains in your head, right about *(pushes fingers into Julie's skull, hard)* here. I don't want any kind of fiasco like we had the last time, okay? I'm the mom: I know what's going on here. So if he asks you questions, you just let me answer.

JULIE: Dr. Phillips breezes in and apologizes for our wait. Mom gives him an update on my allergy diet and pulls out her list of new symptoms. I sit in my sick pose. As she runs down the symptoms, I know some of them aren't true. **(Pg 30)** No, I don't have a sore throat every day, just yesterday. No, my fever last night wasn't way up to 102. No, I don't go to the school nurse every single day . . . [In fact] **(Pg 32)** it was usually after Mom slipped the little white pill under my tongue that my migraines got worse.

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MOM: I can tell you've got a headache coming on. Here, open up. Lift your tongue. Goooood.

JULIE: Sometimes I about threw up. Most times I just needed to climb back into bed . . . **(Pg 50-51)** [Three years pass and] when fifth grade begins, Dr. Phillips prescribes us more migraine medicine and gives us the names of specialists who can see me for the rest of my symptoms. He tells us we should [find] somebody who can handle a case that's as complicated as mine's getting. And then he leaves. He just walks right out before Mom is even done running down the list she brought.

MOM: I can't believe that. Did you see him, Julie? He just walked out on us! Well, if he's going to treat me like that, Jesus!

JULIE: *(resigned)* Don't worry, Mom, we'll just go find another one. **(Pg 52)** *(to audience)* That night Mom curls up on the sofa, with her grocery store reading glasses hanging on to the tip of her nose, cornering through the pages of the thick Medical Journal for Home Use Manual. *(to Mom)* Whatcha doing, Mommy?

MOM: Well, you're sick again, hon, and this book is helping

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Mommy figure out what's wrong with you. You got a lot of the symptoms in here, but there's all kinds of tests that'll help us rule out some of the more serious diseases.

JULIE: [Later that night] **(Pg 84-86)** the doorknob on my bedroom door slowly squeaks open. Mom tiptoes to the edge of my bed. That's when I notice the gun in her mouth. *(Julie enters flashback ad responds immediately with a look of horror)* She looks at me with her tear-streaked, puffy face, her eyes terrified like an animal in a chute, and raises her hand to cock the trigger. "Mommy, Mommy, Mommy!" *(to audience)* I shoot from under the covers and start crying on cue. Mimic and match. If I mirror her with an appropriate response, she'll be distracted from the gun.

MOM: *(she slides the gun out of her mouth)* You want me to kill myself, don't you? You hate me. I'm such a bitch, such a nag as your father says, and you hate me, that's what he says.

JULIE: She drops the gun to her lap. I cling around her like a baby monkey. *(To Mom)* Mom, if you don't live then I can't live. Okay? Okay? Who would take care of me

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when I'm sick; who would take me to the doctor? *(to audience)* I hang on to her, slipping the gun so lightly from her lap she doesn't notice, sliding it under my blankets. *(To Mom)* It's okay, it's okay, Mom. *(to audience)* And the harder I cry, the less my beautiful mother, who I could never live a second without, does. And then she stops altogether, straightens up, gives my knee a little squeeze and says

MOM: *(in an upbeat mood; cheerful)* Hey, thanks for listening, Sis. You better get to sleep now, honey.

JULIE: And she leaves me on the edge of my mattress with a loaded gun under my covers.

[*Spoken Transition -- A few weeks later]

DOCTOR: **(Pg 97-101)** There's a substantial difference in Julie's heart rate when she stands up from when she's at rest, Ms. Gregory.

MOM: *(to Julie)* Tell her how out of breath you are, Julie. *(to doctor)* She's always out of breath around the farm, Dr. Kate. Jesus! *(slaps her knee)* This explains everything. *(to Julie)* You look like you're about ready to pass out, hon. Don't you feel like you could pass out?

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DOCTOR: I think we might have something for the hospital here, something that could be detected with simple EKG or a heart exam. They might even want to attach something called a Holter monitor on her overnight to see the longer rhythms of her heart. I'll call over to the cardiac unit and get you set up.

MOM: Yess – Yeeeessss! *(gleefully)* Finally, we're getting somewhere. *(to Julie)* I knew there was something major going on with you!

JULIE: We're going to the hospital! At last, I'll just take one medication that will fix everything. I'll have friends, be in sports, go to movies. And I'll be a real kid and not miss school anymore. I'll do good in school like before I got sick. I'm [only] failing because there's always something wrong with me.

[*Spoken Transition -- After the cardiac tests]

DOCTOR: **(Pg 101)** Well, Ms. Gregory, we've got good news. The Holter monitor shows no significant findings that lead us to believe Julie has a heart condition requiring further tests.

MOM: What? What do you mean, you can't find anything. This kid had a racing heart and was out of breath all the

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time. Are you trying to tell me that this kid is normal? That I'm making this up? Well, let me tell you. I'm going to find a doctor competent enough to find out what's wrong with her, you understand me?

JULIE: **(Pg 104-105)** The older I got, the worse I got. My possible conditions expanded to include genetic disorders and heart valve malfunctions. And the medications to treat them piled up in the kitchen cabinets. Sometimes I don't take any, sometimes I get a double dose. I just feel sick all the time. Queasy, nauseated, clammy, stupid. . . By the time I was in Junior High, Mom decided I was allergic to a lot of things.

MOM: Julie, what the heck are you doing with those [eggs]? You know you're allergic.

JULIE: I slide the eggs back and reach for the bacon.

MOM: At-at-at, we just got done telling Dr. Kate how meat makes you sick. Why don't you just have a bowl of Sugar Pops? But use the powdered milk, just enough to get them wet, you could be lactose intolerant.

JULIE: **(Pg 111)** How long can you starve without side effects? If everyone around you tells you you're sick, if

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they keep testing you for what's making you sick, do you think, when you're thirteen, that you aren't? You feel sick, right? You can't keep up; you're tired. Is it the wrong mediation that makes you sick? Or the three different kinds you take all at once? . . . . **(Pg 113-114)** We're on our way to a new cardiologist. This will be the third and if he can't find anything, Dr. Kate says it's probably not my heart.

MOM: I'll show those goddam no-good sons a bitches at the hospital that I'm not crazy. You are sick, goddammit, you've got a heart problem. *(glaring at Julie)* C'mon now, let's get in there, and I mean now, goddammit. You are going to tell him what's wrong with you. Sharp chest pain. Shortness of breath. You got it?

[*Spoken Transition -- So more tests are run and when the results come back . . .]

DOCTOR: **(Pg 115-116)** Well, it looks like what we've got here is a possible case of periodic rapid heart action.

MOM: Does that mean we'll have to go in for open-heart? I mean seriously, I'm not opposed to it if we can really find out what's going on here. I've been reading up on

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a new pediatric valve syndrome, and . . .

DOCTOR: Oh, no, I don't think we're going to need that. What we really should do is some more tests under the close eye of hospital staff. Could we get Julie into Ohio State for a week and run a comprehensive assessment?

[*Spoken Transition -- After 4 days in the hospital]

NURSE: **(Pg 121-124)** We're going to have to shave you now, honey. Down here. *(pats for Julie's pubic bone)*

JULIE: What? I'm done, I'm going home. I don't have anything down there! *(covering her private parts)* I'm here for my heart!

NURSE: Tomorrow they're going to make a little incision in the vein of your arm and the artery of your thigh and run some electrical connectors into the values of your heart so they can see it on TV.

JULIE: *(to audience)* This has got to be a mistake. How did this happen? They're going to cut me. *(breath quickens, as Julie's eyes widen in horror – To nurse)* You, you can't do this to me. You can't do it . . . My mother is making it up! *(long horrified pause then to audience)* I can't believe I blurted that out. My mother loves me. There's ***something*** wrong with me. If I

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wasn't sick the doctors wouldn't keep trying to fix me . . . Maybe I was acting sicker because [mom] slammed my head against the inside of the window on the way home if I didn't show them how sick I was.

NURSE: *(puzzled)* Be back in a sec. Let me see what's going on.

JULIE: Mom'll be furious! . . . I don't care. I can run away. Find a new family. . . . [No,] Mom knows what she's doing. She's the one who sees my symptoms.

(Pg 131) Heart surgery, iodine injections, tubes shoved, slits sliced, blood drawn. These things change a kid. You forget what you were like before they cut you, before they shaved you. You only look to the future when they'll find what's wrong so it can all be over; the tests, the trying, the meds you swallow without knowing why.

[Today, as an adult] **(Pg 221-222)** I cry from the guilt of betraying my mother, for not keeping the shroud of her secrets. I have been writing about what it feels like to be cut open while your mother's tight, thin smile mouths, ***"Doctor's orders, honey."*** And to believe you

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are genuinely ill because that is what everything in your world mirrors back to you. I still told myself that it was okay, it really wasn't that bad . . . [after all,] if a doctor couldn't decipher what she did, how could I?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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